Partners.net
info@partners.net

Partners of the Americas
1424 K Street NW, Suite 700
Washington, D.C. 20005

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Ms. Cara Vileno
Lead Program Analyst Labor Rights
Office of Global Programs
Bureau of Democracy, Human Rights, and Labor
U.S. Department of State
2201 C St., NW
Washington, DC 20520

Dear Ms. Vileno,

I hope this message finds you well.

Through this letter, Partners of the Americas (Partners), would like to provide justification for a six-month no-cost extension through September 30, 2023, for the Mexico United 2026 project (award number SLMAQM20GR2337) financed by the U.S. Department of State (DOS). This extension will allow the Mexico United 2026 project to carry out the activities designed to capitalize on recent partnerships forged between the project and key Government of Mexico (GOM) entities and broaden the scope of awareness-raising efforts on human and labor rights in the context of the 2026 *Fédération Internationale De Football Association* (FIFA) World Cup in Mexico.

Over the past several months, the project has been in close contact with the Mexican National Human Rights Commission (CNDH) and the Mexican Youth Institute (IMJUVE) following the signing of a Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) with each agency in November and December 2022, respectively. These strategic alliances will serve to support the project in continued awareness-raising activities regarding labor and human rights associated with mega sporting event activities, employers' responsibility to respect the rights of their employers, and appropriate mechanisms for reporting human rights violations.

Considering these key partnerships, as well as in the context of growing interest in the 2026 FIFA World Cup and the activities of the Mexico United 2026 project, along with recovering time from the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic in the startup of this project awarded in September 2020, Partners proposes to amplify the reach of ongoing activities, to be extended through the no cost extension period between March and September 2023.

The project will engage CNDH and IMJUVE to continue awareness-raising efforts, furthering the objective of the project to inform workers, employers, and the general public of human rights risks and the commitments of the GOM surrounding the 2026 FIFA World Cup:

Activity 1: Partners will work with CNDH to develop and publish electronic awareness-raising materials on human rights in mega sporting events, the responsibility of companies to respect human labor rights, human rights risks, individuals and groups that are most vulnerable due to the activities of mega sporting events, the redress mechanism for victims of abuses committed by companies, and other available complaint mechanisms and legal advice on labor issues. These materials will include a virtual document, four infographics, an animated infographic, and a video.

Activity 2: Partners will work with CNDH to hold a virtual event on the human rights approach in the context of labor activities for the preparation and celebration of the 2026 FIFA World Cup. The event will be targeted towards workers, workers' organizations, human rights defenders and the general public. The project will invite implementing partners, including other Partners projects, and key stakeholders, along with other labor-rights focused projects in Mexico financed by the U.S. Department of Labor (USDOL), to participate in the event and provide insights into labor and human rights in the Mexican context. The event will address topics such as labor and human rights, a gender perspective, the role of workers' organizations in the defense of workers' rights, and new business challenges arising from the 2019 Mexican Labor Reform as they relate to preparation for the 2026 FIFA World Cup.

Activity 3: Partners will work with IMJUVE to generate and publish electronic awareness materials, including a document and an animated infographic, on the labor human rights of young people in mega sporting events. These materials will provide a youth perspective to the discussion of labor rights defense surrounding the 2026 FIFA World Cup.

Activity 4: Partners will host a virtual event to celebrate the International Day of Sport for Development and Peace (April 6, 2023) to highlight the importance of incorporating a human rights approach in all activities related to the preparation and hosting of the 2026 FIFA World Cup. The project's sub-awardee organizations, GOM entities, and other key stakeholders will be invited to participate and share their perspectives regarding the relationship between sport and the defense of human rights.

Additionally, under a no-cost extension, Mexico United 2026's Project Coordinator, Ms. Saskia Cabrera, will have the opportunity to attend DMP Group's workshop, allowing her to learn and refine project management skills that would facilitate efficient and thorough project implementation under this extension and any future extensions of the program.

Activity 5: Ms. Cabrera will participate in the in-person workshop hosted by the DMP Group in San Jose, Costa Rica, in April 2023. The workshop will provide trainings and reinforce Ms. Cabrera's skills regarding financial management, internal controls, procurement, human resources matters, and compliance with donor requirements.

Throughout the life of the project, the *Red Mexico Unido 2026* (Mexico United 2026 Network) has provided a space for Partners, implementing organizations, and other key stakeholders

to collaborate and coordinate efforts to defend the rights of workers in the context of the 2026 FIFA World Cup. Members of the network have worked to engage key actors and raise awareness among human rights defenders, workers, and the general public of risks to labor rights and mitigation strategies. The Network has recently been in contact with FIFA and has been positioned as their primary point of contact for issues regarding human rights and the 2026 World Cup. A no-cost extension of the Mexico United 2026 project will facilitate continued collaboration between FIFA and the Network, streamlining and strengthening efforts to promote human and labor rights.

> Activities 6 and 7: Partners will continue to organize bimonthly virtual meetings with the member organizations of the Mexico United 2026 Network to discuss different topics related to the defense of human and labor rights in the context of the 2026 FIFA World Cup. The Network will continue its efforts to secure the participation of relevant civil society organizations, government entities (including the CNDH and IMJUVE), and the private sector (such as FIFA) in its activities.

We believe that the above activities will contribute significantly to build off ongoing activities and further advance the objectives of the Mexico United 2026 project. An additional six months of implementation would allow the project to continue raising awareness and engaging stakeholders to promote the defense of human and labor rights as we get closer to the realization of the 2026 FIFA World Cup.

We very much appreciate DOS' consideration of Partners' request for a no-cost extension of the Mexico United 2026 project. Please let me know if you have any questions, or if I can provide any additional information about the items discussed in this letter.

Sincerely,

Carmen Peña

Carmen S. Peña
Senior Vice President, Programs
Partners of the Americas

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